

Reader revenue acquisition at the Guardian – some lessons learned

March 2023

Jesse Wilkins, Senior Growth Manager, Global Reader Revenues

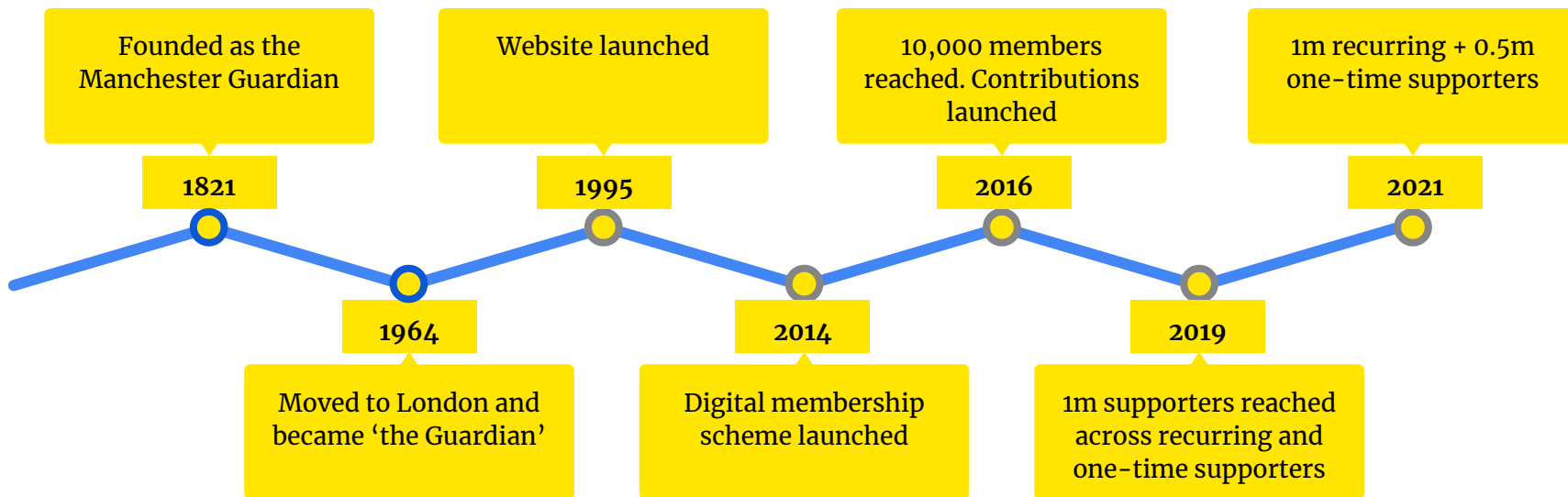
**The
Guardian**

What I'll talk about

1. Who we are
2. Introducing a key acquisitions channel
3. Optimising message copy
4. Optimising everything else
5. Key insights

Who we are

A timeline



The Guardian today

1990S = 8th biggest UK paper



2023 = 364m site visits, #7 global news site*



Free & open model = no paywall

£76m in digital reader revenues in 21/22

55% digital reader revenues = outside of UK

Guardian Support = voluntary payment
(includes legacy products: membership, subscriptions
and contributions)

Supporters are most likely
to live in:

1. The US 
2. The UK 
3. Australia 
4. Canada 
5. Germany 
6. Ireland 
7. France 
8. Netherlands 
9. Italy 
10. Sweden 

**Introducing a key
acquisitions channel**

Inserting the ask into the reader experience: The Epic

Key Lessons:

Traditional 'ad' slots nowhere near as powerful as asks that are deeply complementary to the journalism.

Think 'native' for:

- ~ Design
- ~ Tone-of-voice
- ~ Content and context

The end of an article is our most lucrative real estate.

The 'Epic' became our primary acquisition channel.

Since you're here ...

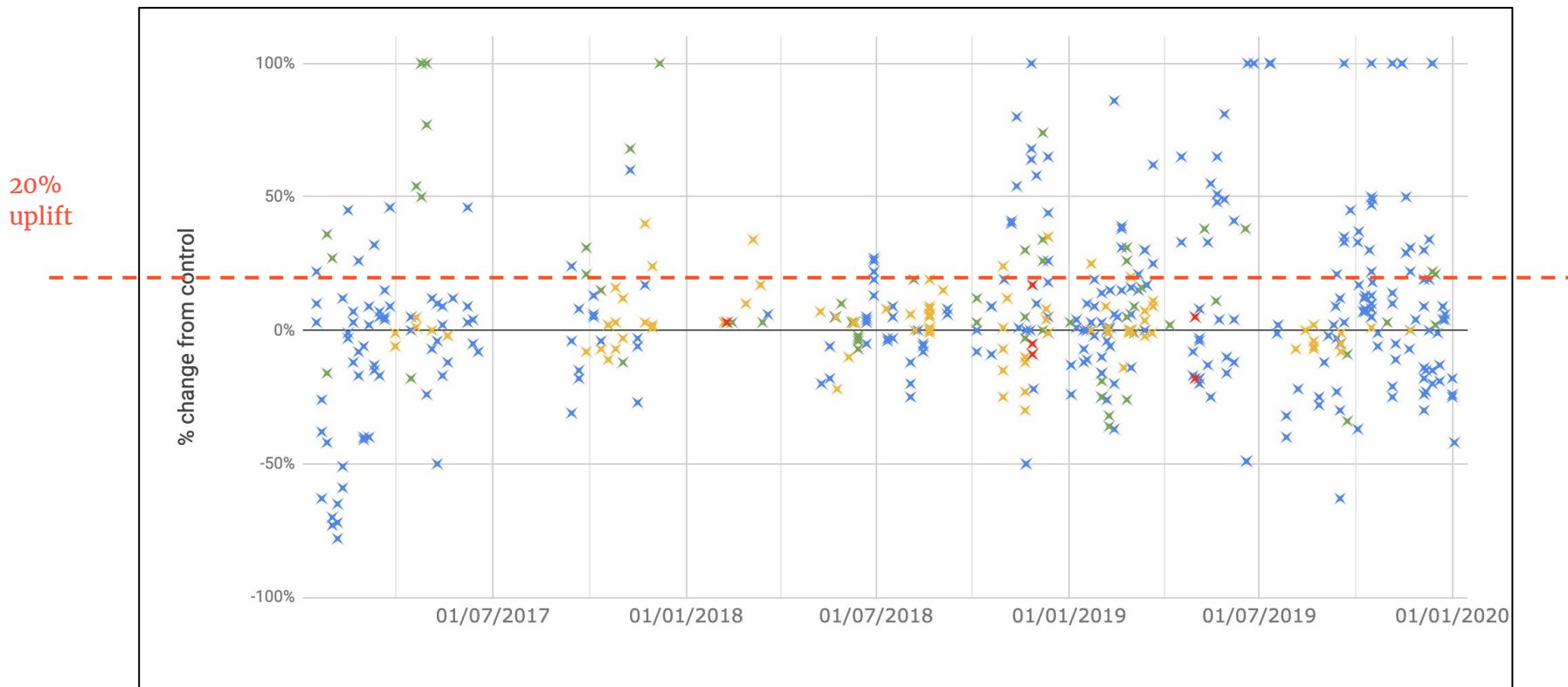
... we've got a small favour to ask. More people are reading the Guardian than ever, but far fewer are paying for it. Advertising revenues across the media are falling fast. And unlike many news organisations, we haven't put up a paywall - we want to keep our journalism as open as we can. So you can see why we need to ask for your help. The Guardian's independent, investigative journalism takes a lot of time, money and hard work to produce. But we do it because we believe our perspective matters - because it might well be your perspective, too.

If everyone who reads our reporting, who likes it, helps to support it, our future would be much more secure.

[Become a supporter →](#)

[Make a contribution →](#)

High traffic + free and open model = lots of opportunity to experiment

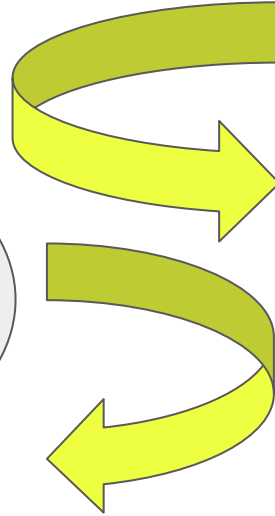


Data: qual and quant, internal and external

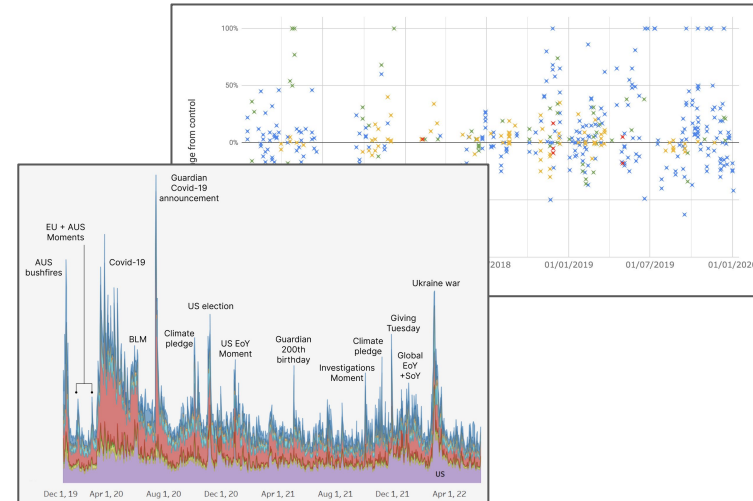
"I believe in journalistic independence as an indispensable element for public supervision of democracy."

"Please don't send me a tote bag - I just want to fund journalism"

"Knowing that others around the world support this too is very powerful"



section_id	£ per 1,000 pageviews
business	£1.04
us-news	£2.32
sport	£0.61
environment	£2.87



Optimising message copy

Learn what makes them tick ...

‘Supporter motivations’ are a critical building block for driving acquisition and creating a two-way dialogue with our readers and supporters. These are largely **global**, **product agnostic**, and **stable** over time.

#1 Editorial independence

#2 Protect the free press

#3 Investigative journalism

#4 Trustworthy, factual, high quality

#5 Holds power to account

#6 Open for all, no paywall

#7 International perspective

#8 Financial challenges in media

#9 Better understand world events

#10 It's only fair to pay

And translate those motivations into impactful copy

A polite opening tone that invokes curiosity and reaches out to readers – but is not pushy

Since you're here...

... we have a small favour to ask. More people, like you, are reading and supporting the Guardian's independent, investigative journalism than ever before. Unlike many news organisations, we made the choice to keep our reporting open for all, regardless of where they live or what they can afford to pay.

Highlights how critical we believe equal access to quality reporting is (a value our supporters share)

The Guardian will engage with the most critical issues of our time – from the escalating climate catastrophe to widespread inequality to the influence of big tech on our lives. At a time when factual information is a necessity, we believe that each of us, around the world, deserves access to accurate reporting with integrity at its heart.

Contextualises our ask in the state of the world and the reporting standards we uphold

Gives sufficient space to explain our independence, what it enables and how it makes us different

Our editorial independence means we set our own agenda and voice our own opinions. Guardian journalism is free from commercial and political bias and not influenced by billionaire owners or shareholders. This means we can give a voice to those less heard, explore where others turn away, and rigorously challenge those in power.

Articulates the value exchange: regular readers are motivated by the volume; occasional readers simply by the reminder

You've read 606 articles in the last four months. With your support we can keep delivering quality journalism that's open and independent. Every reader contribution, however big or small, is so valuable. **Support the Guardian from as little as £1 – and it only takes a minute. Thank you.**

Makes it clear we are asking for financial support and creates a low barrier for entry – you do not need to give a lot to have an impact

Support The Guardian →

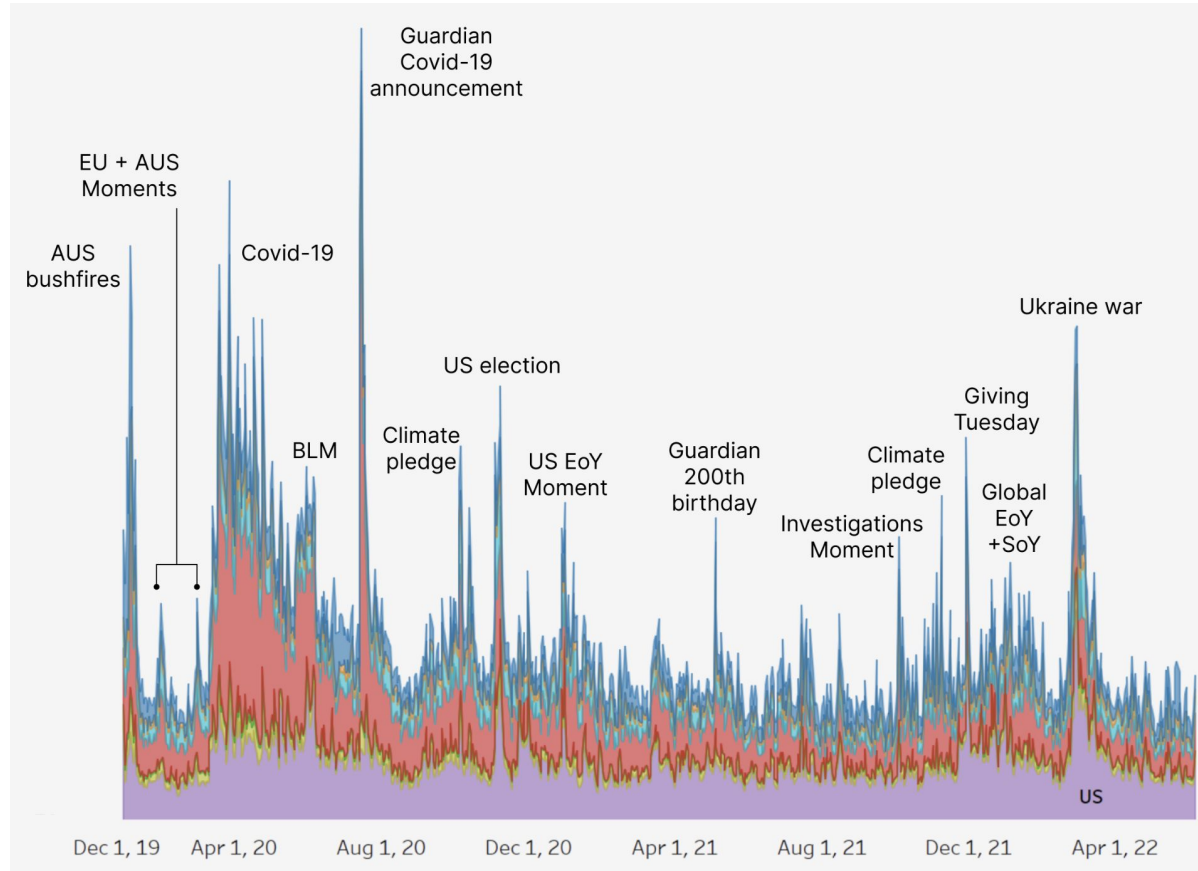
VISA

Mastercard

AMERICAN EXPRESS

PayPal

Leaning into the news cycle ...



And speak to events

As the climate crisis escalates...

+50%

... the Guardian will not stay quiet. This is our pledge: we will continue to give global heating, wildlife extinction and pollution the urgent attention and prominence they demand. The Guardian recognises the climate emergency as the defining issue of our times.

A Joe Biden presidency ...

+150%

... could be on the horizon for the US and the world. Americans have voted to decide whether Donald Trump remains in the White House. The result will have decade-defining consequences - for global democracy and progress. Transatlantic ties, superpower relations and the climate emergency are all in the balance. The next president will set the agenda for the struggle against Covid-19, and the fight for racial justice, gender equality and the fair distribution of wealth.

You've read **29 articles** in the last year

+78%

I'm back in Ukraine, where I've spent much of this year covering Europe's biggest war since 1945. It has been the most intense time of my 30-year career. I've reported on mass graves and the aftermath of deadly bombings. I've spoken to Ukrainians tortured by Russian forces, and relatives of those murdered. The work is all-consuming.

For Ukrainians, this war is an existential struggle against a new but familiar Russian imperialism. Our team of reporters and editors intend to cover this war for as long as it lasts, however expensive that may prove to be. We are committed to telling the human stories of those caught up in war, as well as the international dimension. But we can't do this without funding from Guardian readers. It is your passion, engagement and financial support which underpins our independent journalism and makes it possible for us to report from places like Ukraine.

If you are able to show your support for our work today, you can do so from just £1, or give a little more on a regular basis. This makes a real difference; it will boost our resources and enhance our ability to report the truth about what is happening in this terrible conflict.

Thank you.

Luke Harding

Foreign correspondent



Single

Monthly

Annual

£3 per month

£6 per month

Other

Continue →

Remind me in December



More than one way to speak to the news



'It's the Guardian-reading, tofu-eating wokerati': Suella Braverman launches savage blast at two men who blocked Dartford Crossing in Just Stop Oil protest

By Daily Mail Reporter
22:01, 18 Oct 2022, updated 17:31, 19 Oct 2022



 +6
View gallery

A message for the tofu-eating wokerati...

+70%

You've read 13 articles in the last year

... whatever thwarted politicians might call us, we are proud to say we're a reader-funded global news organisation, with more than 1.5 million supporters in 180 countries. This vital support keeps us fiercely independent, free from shareholders or a billionaire owner. It allows us to keep our reporting open for all, as we know not everyone is in a position to pay for news. **But if you are, we need you.** Make an investment in quality journalism, so millions more can benefit. **Support the Guardian from as little as £1. Thank you.**

Support us monthly →



Support just once →

You've read 92 articles in the last year

+298%

WHAT'S THAT? YOU'RE DESPERATE TO SUPPORT FEARLESS JOURNALISM, INDEPENDENT FROM **THE MAN**? YOU THE GUARDIAN'S SPORT COVERAGE AND THE PEEKERS WRITING OF...



YOU'RE EVEN PREPARED TO OVERLOOK THE FOOTBALL CARTOONIST'S UNHEALTHY OBSESSION WITH JOSE MORRINO?



WELL YOU'RE IN LUCK, MY FRIEND, BECAUSE FOR A MODEST SUM, YOU CAN HELP POWER OUR JOURNALISM, SUSTAIN OUR FUTURE, AND KEEP THAT HEROIC AND HUMBLE CARTOONIST IN THE LIFESTYLE TO WHICH HE HAS BECOME ACCUSTOMED.



SUPPORT THE GUARDIAN FOR AS LITTLE AS ONE POUND / EURO / DOLLAR - IT ONLY TAKES A MINUTE. IF YOU CAN, PLEASE CONSIDER SUPPORTING US WITH A REGULAR AMOUNT EACH MONTH. THANK YOU X

Single Monthly Annual

£3 per month £6 per month Other

Continue →

Remind me in May

VISA Mastercard

Failure has taught us a lot too

As the pandemic resurges ...

– 37%

... and intensifies across the UK and Europe, the Guardian's journalism is vital. We promise to bring you high-quality, independent reporting, and expert, science-led analysis that you can trust, countering misinformation and sensationalism. We'll continue to scrutinise policies and challenge those in power to take more decisive, effective measures. With each of us feeling the pressure, we're here to help you feel informed and prepared.

You've read 1598 articles in the last year. And you're not alone; millions are flocking to the Guardian for open, independent, quality news every day, and readers in 180 countries around the world now support us financially.

We believe everyone deserves access to trustworthy information. That's why we choose to keep our reporting open for all readers, regardless of where they live or what they can afford to pay.

This Valentine's Day ...

– 40%

... show your love for independent journalism. Commitment can be hard. We get it. But at the Guardian we feel that straightforward commitment to truth and openness is more important than ever. That's why we promise to remain true, to cut through the fake news, and always stay faithful to our readers' needs. We also know you can be committed without giving up your independence, which is why we think you'll appreciate our unique ownership structure - free from bias, free from censorship, and dedicated to always meeting the highest standards. All we ask is that you support us, in whatever way you can, with whatever you have to give. If you love our work, and value the power of independent journalism, please support the Guardian. A little love goes a long way. **Support The Guardian from as little as \$1 - and it only takes a minute. Thank you.**

Support The Guardian →



Optimising everything else

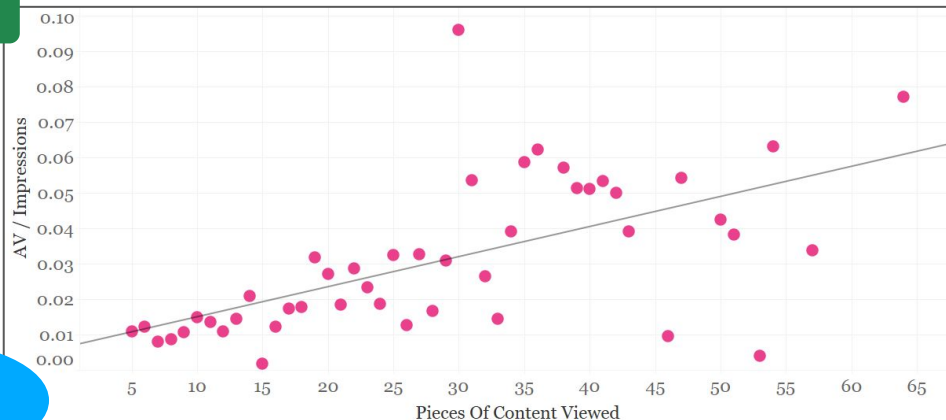
Article count - a 'fitbit for news'

*Congratulations on being one of our top readers globally - you've read **559 articles** in the last year*

... as 2023 gathers pace, and you're joining us from Italy, we have a small favour to ask. A new year means n

+59%

£5.8m



When and where to ask

Key Lessons

Content varies in yield of converted readers

Often surprised by high performers, out of hundreds of articles per day

‘Supermode’: inhouse custom-built system to check every article every hour in each region, and react accordingly

section_id	£ per 1,000 pageviews
business	£1.04
us-news	£2.32
sport	£0.61
environment	£2.87

£1.5m

Title	£AV per 1,000 pageviews	£AV	N. of conversions	pageviews
world/2021/may/05/mali-woman-has-given-birth-to-nine-babies-says-health-ministry	£0.00	£0	0	29,787
world/2021/may/05/napoleon-is-part-of-us-macron-tells-france-after-row-over-anniversary	£0.00	£0	0	43,114
uk-news/2021/may/05/julia-james-killing-police-release-new-image-of-victim	£0.00	£0	0	32,596
australia-news/2021/may/05/brisbane-father-of-two-claims-2m-in-damages-after-being-jailed	£0.11	£3	1	24,615
media/2021/may/06/guardian-200-ad-that-saved-jewish-father-from-nazis	£11.95	£4,111	101	344,064
commentisfree/2021/may/05/the-guardian-view-on-foreign-policy-after-brexite-growing-pains	£6.56	£316	12	48,144

Integrating the payment flow into the ask

Tens of millions have placed their trust in the Guardian's high-impact journalism since we started publishing 200 years ago, turning to us in moments of crisis, uncertainty, solidarity and hope. More than 1.5 million readers, from 180 countries, have recently taken the step to support us financially - keeping us open to all, and fiercely independent.

If there were ever a time to join us, it is now. Every contribution, however big or small, powers our journalism and sustains our future. **Support the Guardian from as little as £1 - it only takes a minute. If you can, please consider supporting us with a regular amount each month. Thank you.**

Support the Guardian →

Remind me in September

VISA Mastercard American Express PayPal



United Kingdom £ ▾

The Guardian

Support fearless, independent journalism

Single	Monthly	Annual
£3 per month	£5 per month	
£7 per month	£10 per month	
Choose your amount		



With your support, we'll continue to keep Guardian journalism open and free for everyone to read. When access to information is made equal, greater numbers of people can understand global events and their impact on people and communities. Together, we can demand better from the powerful and fight for democracy.

Whether you give a little or a lot, your funding will power our reporting for the years to come. **Support the Guardian from as little as £1 - it only takes a minute. If you can, please consider giving a regular amount each month or year. Thank you.**

Single	Monthly	Annual
£3 per month	£5 per month	Other

Continue → Remind me in March VISA Mastercard American Express PayPal

+48%

£1.4m

'Remind me later' emails

Key Insight

Over half our one-time contributors said they were willing to be reminded to give again in the future, under certain conditions.

Prompting me is the only way someone like me will give again! We need the reminder.

I would have to be prompted again either via email or via the site. With life's pace I wouldn't remember on my own.

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Single	Monthly	Annual
£6 per month	£12 per month	Other
Continue →	Remind me in September	VISA Mastercard American Express PayPal

You said we could ask in
September ▶ Inbox



'The Guardian' via Mar... 15/09/2022
to marketing ▼

**The
Guardian**

Dear reader,

On 4 August you read a Guardian article and asked us to invite you to support us this September. We hope now is still a good time. This kind of support means we can continue upholding our ideals of fairness, information and editorial independence. You can
ence today from as little as \$1.

£2.3m

Key insights

Putting it all together

41% of
acquisitions £ in
2023

Quantify how much you've read

Acknowledge you are a
top reader

Speak to the story you've just read

Why we believe in open journalism

Show the different and flexible ways to
support

*Congratulations on being one of our top readers globally
- you've read **800 articles** in the last year* Article count on

The Guardian has spent the past 13 years tirelessly investigating the shortcomings of the Tories in office - austerity, Brexit, partygate, cronyism, the Truss debacle and the individual failings of ministers who behave as if the rules don't apply to them.

Our work has resulted in resignations, apologies and policy corrections. Our continued revelations about the conveyor belt of Tory dysfunction are the latest in a long line of important scoops. And with an election just round the corner, we won't stop now. It's crucial that we can all make informed decisions about who is best to lead the UK. [Will you invest in the Guardian this year?](#)

Unlike many others, the Guardian has no shareholders and no billionaire owner. Just the determination and passion to deliver high-impact global reporting, always free from commercial or political influence. Reporting like this is vital for democracy, for fairness and to demand better from the powerful.

And we provide all this for free, for everyone to read. We do this because we believe in information equality. Greater numbers of people can keep track of the events shaping our world, understand their impact on people and communities, and become inspired to take meaningful action. Millions can benefit from open access to quality, truthful news, regardless of their ability to pay for it.

Whether you give a little or a lot, your funding will power our reporting for the years to come. **If you can, please support us on a monthly basis from just £2. It takes less than a minute to set up, and you can rest assured that you're making a big impact every single month in support of open, independent journalism. Thank you.**

Single

Monthly

Annual

£3 per month

£5 per month

Other

Continue →

Remind me in April



Explain our independence and
what it enables us to do

Politely nudge (not shove)
towards a recurring payment

Provide an option to support later

Still a work in progress

2016

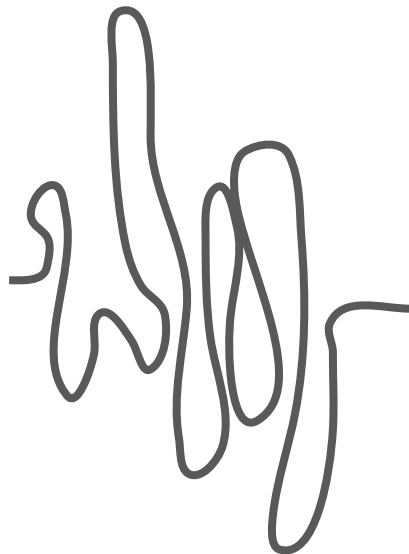
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Become a supporter →

Make a contribution →



2023

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Monthly

Annual

£3 per month

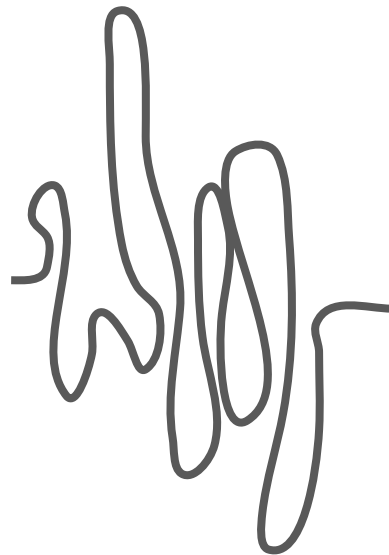
£5 per month

Other

Continue →

Remind me in April

VISA Mastercard PayPal



Thank you for listening

jesse.wilkins@guardian.co.uk